The PCF accepted with alacrity, no doubt thinking that he could mix business with pleasure. On the appointed day, we picked him up in the staff car, and then transferred him on to a mule, before making him walk the rest of the way to the top, where he was received with a chilled glass of beer. Neither the proposed road nor the elusive goral, of which we had not seen hide nor hair, was mentioned throughout the afternoon. About a week after this picnic, we received the sanction to go ahead with the road. Case closed.

Militancy was just rearing its head in the Kashmir Valley, but here, South of the Pir Panjal Range, things were still relatively quiet. There used to be almost daily instances of trans-LC firing, but this was restricted to small arms (SA) fire only. Every morning starting from 0500 hours, the Adjutants would call up and give me the situation report (SITREP) of the night's activities. Which Pakistani post had fired on which post of ours, with which weapons and how many rounds of each (which was more guesswork, one burst being counted as twenty rounds), and our response. If the call came in the morning, it was 'routine'; if a call came at any other time, it meant we had probably suffered some casualties, either killed or injured. Then, we would all get activated, arranging for helicopters to be available at daybreak for casualty evacuation. That's what the 'Staff' was there for, to take care of the paperwork, the back end, leaving the fighting units on the 'Line' free of such worries. If it was all routine, I would compile the reports and give the Commander a call by about 0530 hours. Once cleared by him, I'd call the GSO-1 (Operations) at the Divisional HQ, latest by 0600 hours. This was an unwavering routine. A similar procedure was followed for the evening sitrep, which had to be given to the Division latest by 1800 hours. Even at that early hour, Brig Sandhu would catch something that was not quite

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